

# PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

## PRE-RETURN TÜRKİYE

D9.1 - JANUARY 2026

**Rodrigo Bolaños Suárez (bicc)**  
**Zeynep Sahin-Mencutek (bicc)**  
**Soner Barthoma (Uppsala University)**



Funded by  
the European Union

|                                                             |                                                   |                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| <b>Name of practice</b>                                     | <b>Go-and-see Visits (GSVs)</b>                   |                |
| <b>Dates</b>                                                | January – July 2025                               |                |
| <b>Target group</b>                                         | Syrians under temporary protection                |                |
| <b>Geographic Scope</b>                                     | Country                                           | <b>Türkiye</b> |
|                                                             | Regions                                           | Asia, Europe   |
|                                                             | Sub Region                                        | Middle East    |
| <b>Main involving actor(s)</b>                              | Presidency of Migration Management (PMM)<br>UNHCR |                |
| <b>Return Stages</b>                                        | Pre return                                        |                |
| <b>Challenge addressed</b>                                  | Voluntariness and Coercion                        |                |
| <b>Principles referred</b><br><i>(implicit or explicit)</i> | Human-Rights-Based Approach<br>Migrants Agency    |                |

## SUMMARY

The “Go-and-see visits” (GSVs) are when potential returnees are allowed to travel temporarily to their areas of origin in Syria to assess the security situation, access to services, and general living conditions before making a final decision to return.

The visits provide the opportunity to make an informed decision and are an instrument to encourage return. From 2017 to 2022, Syrians were allowed to make GSVs to Syria during religious holidays. Since 2022, Turkish authorities have prevented Syrians who travel home from returning to Türkiye after visiting their homeland during religious holidays due to the intensifying anti-refugee sentiment in Türkiye.

From January 2025 (after the fall of Assad in Syria) to July 2025, the head of the family was allowed to enter/leave the country three times within a six-month time limit. To facilitate GSVs and permanent voluntary returns, the processing capacity of border crossings was increased from 3,000 persons a day to 15,000-20,000 persons a day.

## BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

In May 2025, the Ministry of Interior (MoI) announced that 27,000 “pioneer immigrants” had participated in GSVs. Survey results indicated that the visits had mixed effects on the refugees’ intentions to return (UNHCR 2025). Approximately 46% of the participants felt encouraged to consider returning due to nostalgia, family ties, or hope for stability. Conversely, another 46% were deterred from returning because of harsh living conditions, lack of services, and safety concerns. Only 9% reported that their intentions had not changed. Overall, more than half (57%) of the survey respondents considered the visits helpful for making informed decisions, with 40% describing them as essential and 17% as useful (UNHCR 2025). It is estimated that the number of Syrians under temporary protection has decreased from 3.53 million in 2022 to 2.43 million as of September 2025.

However, this practice has significant limitations. There is a pressured sense of “voluntariness,” as Syrians face persistent challenges in Türkiye, such as discrimination in the labour market, unequal access to education and health services, and exposure to xenophobia, all of which may influence their decisions to return. Conditions in Syria remain precarious, characterized by ongoing insecurity, fragile governance, and limited basic services, undermining prospects for a sustainable return. Additionally, GSVs may create unrealistic expectations about the opportunities for return, rather than offering viable, long-term pathways. Finally, this model primarily serves short-term migration

management goals and does not address the structural requirements necessary for a durable return, such as reconstruction and access to livelihoods in Syria.

## KEY LESSONS

**Information tools alone cannot determine return outcomes.** GSVs can assist in making informed decisions, but they cannot fundamentally alter the overall factors affecting return. While GSVs allow individuals to assess conditions directly, the desire to return is mainly shaped by structural factors such as security, access to services, and livelihoods in the country of origin, as well as the conditions in the host country.

**Voluntariness requires contextual assessment.** Return decisions may reflect cumulative pressures in the host country -such as discrimination, limited access to services, and socio-economic precarity- rather than solely conditions observed in the country of origin. These parameters, including compounded vulnerabilities, need closer examination to avoid conflating informed choice with constrained decision-making.

## RECOMMENDATIONS

**Provide financial and reintegration support alongside monitoring.** GSVs require targeted financial assistance and reintegration support for participants. These support measures should work collaboratively with independent monitoring, allowing return decisions to be assessed against different criteria.

**Restore independent monitoring capacity through sustained international support.** Adequate international funding is required to re-establish independent monitoring of go-and-see visits and return processes, enabling systematic observation of protection risks and longer-term outcomes.

**Integrate gender- and child-sensitive considerations into visit design.** Go-and-see visit frameworks should explicitly account for differentiated risks and vulnerabilities, reflecting the specific situations of women and children throughout the decision-making process.

## REFERENCES

Yerlikaya, A. [@aliyerlikaya]. (2025, November 4). “8 Aralık 2024’ten sonra Suriye’nin özgürleşmesinden bugüne kadar, ülkelerine gönüllü, güvenli, onurlu ve düzenli geri dönüş yapan Suriyeli kardeşlerimizin sayısı 450.169 oldu (...)” [Tweet]. Twitter. <https://x.com/aliyerlikaya/status/1961480876996313471>

PMM. (2025b). “İçişleri Bakanı Ali Yerlikaya, 2016 yılından bu yana gönüllü, güvenli, onurlu ve düzenli geri dönüş yapan Suriyelilerin sayısının 1 milyon 126 bine ulaştığını belirtti. “, <https://www.goc.gov.tr/icisleri-bakani-ali-yerlikaya-2016-yilindan- itibaren- ulkesine-gonullu-geri-donus-yapan-suriyeli-sayisinin-1-milyona-ulastigini- acikla- merkezicerik>

Upinion (2025). “Lessons from go-and-see visits of Syrian refugees in Türkiye.” <https://upinion.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/09/Upinion-Report-Lessons-from-Go-and-See-Visits-of-Syrian-Refugees-in-Turkiye-1.pdf>

UNHCR. (2025). Flash Regional Survey on Syrian Refugees’ Perceptions and Intentions on Return to Syria: Egypt, Iraq, Jordan, Lebanon. MENA Regional Bureau. Available at: <https://data.unhcr.org/en/documents/download/114221>